

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 8: Betrayal

Day 36 Since Awakening

The daily quest completion notification faded as Hayami scrolled through the Hunter job board on their phone. Two days of wind manipulation practice had brought it to E-rank 31%, but they needed combat experience to truly understand how the elements worked together in real situations.

Most of the available jobs were standard fare—D-rank Gates with established teams, mining positions, equipment porter work. Then one listing caught their eye:

[C-Rank Gate Raid - Combat Support Needed]

- **Gate Location:** Nerima District, Gate #NR-892
- **Raid Date:** Today, 14:00
- **Duration:** Estimated 4-6 hours
- **Payment:** ¥180,000
- **Requirements:** C-rank or equivalent combat capability
- **Team Composition:** Independent party, experienced raiders, need 1 additional combat support
- **Note:** Fast-paced clearing style. Must be able to keep up.

C-rank Gate. Independent party rather than guild-affiliated. Higher pay than Sato's jobs. And most importantly—available today.

Hayami applied without hesitation.

The acceptance came within minutes, along with coordinates and a meeting time. They had four hours to prepare.

13:47 - Gate #NR-892 Staging Area

The independent party was already assembled when Hayami arrived. Five Hunters, all wearing matching dark blue combat gear with a wolf emblem—clearly a coordinated team despite not being guild-affiliated.

The leader stepped forward immediately. He was in his early thirties, with the kind of confidence that came from hundreds of successful raids. His license showed C-rank, Level 38.

"You must be Amamiya." He extended his hand. "Nakamura Shin. Party leader. Glad you could make it on short notice."

Hayami shook his hand, noting the firm grip and the way Nakamura's eyes assessed their equipment. "Thanks for the opportunity."

"That's some impressive gear for an E-rank." Nakamura gestured at Hayami's cloak and gauntlets. "You punch above your weight?"

"I manage."

"Good. We move fast and clear efficiently. Our usual support guy is in the hospital after a D-rank Gate went sideways, so we need someone who can handle themselves." He turned to address the full group. "We're still waiting on one more—a new addition. Fresh Awakened with high potential."

As if on cue, another Hunter approached. She was around Hayami's height with shoulder-length brown hair and brown eyes, wearing brand new equipment that still had the shop tags visible. But it was her license that made everyone look twice:

[NAKAYAMA HIMIKO - A-RANK - LEVEL 15]

A-rank. Level 15. Recently Awakened.

The party members immediately straightened up, their casual demeanor shifting to something more respectful. A-ranks were rare—maybe one in ten thousand Awakened. Even a fresh A-rank with low level was worth ten experienced C-ranks.

Himiko looked uncomfortable with the attention. "Hi. I'm Himiko. First Gate raid, so please go easy on me."

"A-rank asking us to go easy?" One of Nakamura's team members—a woman with twin daggers—laughed. "That's a first."

"High rank doesn't mean experienced." Himiko's voice was direct, matter-of-fact. "I Awakened three weeks ago. I have power but no practical combat knowledge. That's why I'm here."

Three weeks. Hayami had Awakened five weeks ago. They'd been at this only slightly longer than Himiko, but the difference in their starting ranks was dramatic.

Nakamura nodded approvingly. "Smart to recognize that. We'll cover the basics as we go." He gestured at Hayami. "You two will be working together—both support combat, handle stragglers and watch our backs. Himiko, with your rank you could probably solo this Gate, but stick with the formation and learn how coordinated teams operate."

Himiko nodded, then noticed Hayami's E-rank license. She didn't say anything, but her expression showed confusion—why was an E-rank on a C-rank raid?

"Alright, everyone." Nakamura pulled up a tablet showing the Gate layout. "This is Serpent's Den. Primary monsters are Shadow Vipers and Stone Serpents, with a boss we've identified as a Basilisk Lord. Standard clear pattern—we've done this Gate four times before, we know the layout. Questions?"

No one had questions.

They entered the Gate.

**[NOTICE: You have entered a C-Rank Gate] [Gate Name: Serpent's Den] [Estimated Difficulty: C]
[Recommended Level: 35-50]**

The Gate interior was a cave system with unnaturally smooth walls, as if something massive had carved tunnels through solid rock. The air was humid and smelled of earth and decay. Bioluminescent fungus provided minimal light, casting everything in sickly green.

Nakamura's team moved with practiced efficiency. They'd clearly run this Gate multiple times—they knew exactly where to step, which tunnels to take, where monsters would spawn.

The first encounter was a group of Shadow Vipers—Level 34 serpents the size of pythons, nearly invisible in the dim light.

[SHADOW VIPER - LEVEL 34] x8 [HP: 3,200/3,200 each]

The main combat team handled six of them with brutal efficiency. Two vipers broke through the formation, heading for the support position.

Hayami and Himiko reacted simultaneously.

Hayami's Advanced Lightning Strike caught the first viper mid-strike, the bolt punching through its skull with explosive force. The second viper changed targets toward Himiko—

Who transformed mid-dodge.

One moment she was human. The next, she was the viper—perfect mimicry, down to the scale patterns. The real viper, confused by its own reflection, hesitated. That hesitation was fatal. Himiko shifted back to human form and drove a knife through the creature's brain.

[SHADOW VIPER DEFEATED] x2 [+2,560 EXP]

Hayami stared. Shapeshifting. Full body transformation. That was an absurdly rare ability, easily A-rank worthy.

Himiko caught their expression and shrugged. "Shapeshifting. It's... pretty much all I've got right now. Still learning how to use it in combat."

"That was impressive," Hayami said honestly.

"Thanks. Your lightning was pretty impressive too." Himiko glanced at Hayami's license again, clearly doing mental math. "You're definitely not a normal E-rank."

Before Hayami could respond, Nakamura called back. "Good work, support team. Keep that up."

The raid progressed smoothly. Too smoothly. Nakamura's team moved through the Gate like they had a blueprint, clearing chamber after chamber with mechanical precision. Every monster position predicted. Every ambush expected. Every trap avoided before it could trigger.

Hayami's Enhanced Perception and Seismic Sense were picking up something else—subtle vibrations, the sound of whispered conversations when the team thought no one was listening, glances exchanged between party members that had nothing to do with combat tactics.

Something was wrong.

Himiko noticed Hayami's tension. "You okay?" she whispered during a brief rest.

"Stay alert," Hayami murmured back. "Something feels off."

Himiko's expression sharpened. She nodded once, trusting the warning.

They reached the boss chamber faster than Nakamura had estimated. The entrance was a massive archway carved with serpent motifs, leading into a circular arena the size of a basketball court.

And in the center, coiled around a pillar of stone, was the Basilisk Lord.

[BASILISK LORD - LEVEL 45] [BOSS MONSTER] [HP: 42,000/42,000] [STATUS: SLEEPING]

It was massive—ten meters long, covered in scales that looked like polished obsidian, with a crown of bone spikes around its head. Even sleeping, it radiated menace.

Nakamura held up a fist—the signal to stop. The team froze. He studied the sleeping boss for a long moment, then turned to address the group.

"The boss is still asleep. This is perfect." He gestured to his main combat team. "We're going to go back and grab mining gear. No point wasting the resources in the cleared chambers. Amamiya, Himiko—you two keep watch here. If the boss wakes up, don't engage. Just retreat to the tunnel and wait for us."

Hayami's instincts screamed. "We should all go together."

"No need. This boss has a thirty-minute wake cycle. We've timed it before." Nakamura's smile didn't reach his eyes. "You'll be fine. Just watch and wait."

The main team retreated back through the tunnel they'd entered from. Hayami watched them go, every sense on high alert.

Himiko moved closer. "This doesn't feel right."

"It's not." Hayami's hand was already on Storm Fang's hilt. "They're—"

The sound of stone grinding against stone echoed through the chamber. Hayami spun toward the tunnel entrance just in time to see a massive stone door—one they hadn't noticed on the way in—sliding closed.

They ran. Lightning Step carried Hayami to the door in a fraction of a second, but they were too late. The stone sealed with a sound of finality, cutting them off from the tunnel.

And behind them, the Basilisk Lord's eyes opened.

[SYSTEM ALERT]

[URGENT QUEST: SURVIVE THE BASILISK]

[You have been betrayed and trapped with a C-rank boss monster. Defeat the Basilisk Lord or die trying.]

[COMPLETION REWARD: +10,000 EXP, Legendary Reward Box]

[FAILURE PENALTY: DEATH]

The boss uncoiled from its pillar, its movement terrifyingly smooth. Its eyes—multifaceted like a fly's, but each facet glowing with malevolent intelligence—fixed on Hayami and Himiko.

Then it roared, and the sound was like reality tearing.

"MOVE!" Hayami grabbed Himiko and activated Lightning Step, carrying both of them aside as the Basilisk's tail smashed into the ground where they'd been standing. The impact cracked stone and sent debris flying.

Himiko shifted into a smaller form—a snake, racing across the floor toward cover. Smart. Smaller target, harder to hit.

Hayami analyzed the situation in the fraction of a second their Enhanced Perception allowed. Level 45 boss. 42,000 HP. Unknown abilities. Enclosed space with no escape.

Two options: kill it or die.

"Himiko!" Hayami called out. "I'm going to fight it! Can you support?"

The snake transformed back into Himiko, now crouched behind a pillar. "What? You're going to fight a C-rank boss? You're E-rank!"

"No, I'm not. Long story. Can you help or not?"

Himiko stared for a moment, then her expression hardened with determination. "Tell me what you need."

"Distraction. Harassment. Anything to split its attention." Hayami drew Storm Fang, lightning crackling along the blade. "I'll do the damage."

The Basilisk attacked again, its massive head striking like a battering ram. Hayami dove aside, already channeling power.

"Lightning Domain!"

The hemisphere of electrical energy exploded into existence around Hayami. The Basilisk's next attack carried it into the domain's edge, and electricity arced across its scales. The damage was minimal—maybe 200 HP—but it got the creature's attention.

[BASILISK LORD HP: 41,800/42,000]

Himiko shifted forms again, becoming a larger serpent—not quite as large as the Basilisk, but significant. She struck at the boss's flank, fangs seeking gaps in the scales. The Basilisk turned its head to address this new threat.

Hayami didn't waste the opening. Advanced Lightning Strike, channeled through Storm Fang for maximum damage. The bolt caught the Basilisk in its exposed side, and the creature shrieked.

[CRITICAL HIT!] [BASILISK LORD HP: 38,900/42,000]

Nearly three thousand damage in one hit. The Arbiter class's damage bonuses, the equipment enhancements, the C-rank lightning mastery—all of it stacked multiplicatively to turn a strong attack into a devastating one.

But 39,000 HP remaining. This was going to be a long fight.

The Basilisk opened its mouth, and Hayami's Enhanced Perception screamed a warning. They threw themselves flat as a stream of dark purple liquid sprayed over their head—venom that sizzled when it hit stone, eating through rock like acid.

[BASILISK LORD - ABILITY: ACID VENOM]

Noted. Don't get hit by that.

"Earth Wall!" Hayami raised a barrier between themselves and the Basilisk, buying three seconds to plan. The Basilisk smashed through it immediately, but three seconds was enough.

They had three elements now. Lightning for damage. Earth for defense and control. Wind for—

Wind. They'd barely practiced it. E-rank, 31% proficiency. But the Advanced Wind Manipulation Manual had mentioned something about wind enhancing mobility and other elements.

Worth trying.

Hayami channeled wind around their body, feeling it respond sluggishly compared to lightning or earth. They pushed harder, and suddenly the wind caught—wrapping around them like a second skin.

Movement became effortless. Lightning Step activated, and instead of the usual three-second burst, the wind extended it to five. They crossed the chamber in a blur, Storm Fang cutting a line across the Basilisk's exposed underbelly.

[BASILISK LORD HP: 36,400/42,000]

Himiko had shifted to a bird form, diving at the Basilisk's eyes to keep it disoriented. The creature was getting frustrated, its attacks becoming more aggressive and less precise.

Good. Angry enemies made mistakes.

Hayami activated their newly acquired skill. "Stone Spear!"

Three compressed stone projectiles materialized and launched simultaneously, each one dense enough to punch through armor. They struck the Basilisk's side, and the creature roared in pain.

[BASILISK LORD HP: 33,700/42,000]

A third of its health gone. But Hayami's mana was dropping fast—already down to 580/1,130. Lightning Domain alone cost 200 mana, and they'd used multiple high-cost skills.

They needed to be smarter about resource management.

The Basilisk's tail swept in a wide arc, too fast to dodge normally. Hayami raised both hands. "Earth Wall!" Three walls materialized in sequence, each one absorbing part of the impact before shattering. The tail hit Hayami anyway, but weakened—they flew backward into a pillar but survived.

[HP: 398/560]

Pain exploded through their side. Probably cracked ribs. But survivable.

Himiko dove down in bird form, shifted to human, landed on the Basilisk's head, drove her knife into its eye, then shifted to a small lizard to avoid the retaliatory bite. She was learning combat adaptation on the fly, using

her shapeshifting with increasing creativity.

The Basilisk thrashed, partially blinded. Hayami used the opening to drink a mana potion, restoring 200 points.

[MANA: 780/1,130]

Time to use the big skills.

"Himiko! Get clear!" Hayami channeled earth and lightning simultaneously, feeling the Elemental Harmony passive activate. Using multiple elements in combat—40% damage bonus stacking with all their other bonuses.

"Tremor!"

The ground rippled, a localized earthquake spreading from Hayami's position. The Basilisk lost its balance, its massive weight becoming a disadvantage as the floor bucked beneath it.

While it was off-balance: "Chain Lightning!"

The electricity branched from Hayami's outstretched hands, arcing across the Basilisk's entire body. Enhanced by Lightning Domain, boosted by Elemental Harmony, amplified by their equipment—the damage was catastrophic.

[CRITICAL HIT!] [BASILISK LORD HP: 27,100/42,000]

The Basilisk recovered faster than expected, its tail sweeping again. This time Hayami was ready. Wind enhancement increased their speed, allowing them to leap straight up. The tail passed beneath them. They came down on the Basilisk's back, Storm Fang driving deep between scales.

Lightning channeled through the blade directly into the creature's spine.

[CRITICAL HIT!] [BASILISK LORD HP: 23,800/42,000]

Halfway down. But Hayami's mana was at 420. They needed to end this soon.

The Basilisk bucked, throwing Hayami off. They landed hard, rolled, came up with both hands glowing. Earth in the right hand, lightning in the left.

"Advanced Stone Spear! Advanced Lightning Strike!"

The attacks launched simultaneously, catching the Basilisk from both sides. Stone punched through scales, lightning flash-fried internal organs.

[BASILISK LORD HP: 19,200/42,000]

The creature was wounded now, bleeding from multiple wounds, one eye destroyed, moving with less coordination. But still dangerous. Still very much alive.

It opened its mouth for another acid spray. Hayami was out of position, too far to dodge—

Himiko, in the form of a massive bird, slammed into Hayami from the side, carrying them out of the spray's path. They hit the ground together in a tangle of limbs.

"Thanks," Hayami gasped.

"Don't mention it." Himiko shifted back to human form, breathing hard. "How much longer?"

"Forty-five percent health left. Maybe three more minutes." Hayami checked their mana. 280 remaining. "I need you to keep it busy for thirty seconds. Can you do that?"

"I can try." Himiko's expression was grim but determined.

She shifted into the Basilisk's form—perfect mimicry. The real Basilisk paused, confused by its doppelganger. Himiko charged, and the two serpents collided in the center of the chamber.

Hayami used the time to channel power. Not a single big attack—those were mana-inefficient. Instead, a sustained assault.

Lightning Step to close distance. Storm Fang in a precise strike between scales. Step again. Another strike. Wind enhancement making them faster than the Basilisk could track. Strike, step, strike, step.

Death by a thousand cuts, each one channeling lightning through the blade directly into vital organs.

[BASILISK LORD HP: 16,400/42,000] [HP: 14,200/42,000] [HP: 12,100/42,000]

The real Basilisk finally distinguished Himiko from itself and tail-whipped her across the chamber. She hit a wall hard and didn't get up immediately.

But the damage was done. The boss was below 30% health, bleeding from dozens of wounds, exhausted from the sustained combat.

Hayami's mana was at 80. Enough for one more big attack.

They planted their feet, channeled everything they had left—lightning, earth, wind, all three elements spiraling together in a technique they'd never attempted before.

"ELEMENTAL CONVERGENCE!"

The attack wasn't a skill the System had taught them. It was improvised, desperate, pulling on their Arbiter class's multi-element synergy to combine all three elements into a single devastating strike.

Lightning for penetration. Earth for crushing force. Wind to carry it faster than sound.

The combined elemental spear launched from Hayami's hands, crossed the chamber in a flash of blue-white-brown-gray energy, and struck the Basilisk Lord center-mass.

The explosion shook the entire chamber. Stone cracked. The Basilisk's roar cut off mid-sound.

When the dust cleared, the creature was still standing. But barely.

[BASILISK LORD HP: 2,100/42,000]

Five percent. Almost dead. But Hayami's mana was at zero, and their body was reaching its limits. Cracked ribs, bruised organs, muscles screaming from sustained Lightning Step usage.

The Basilisk charged, a final desperate attack.

Hayami drew Storm Fang, let wind enhancement carry them forward to meet it, and drove the blade up through the Basilisk's lower jaw, through its skull, into its brain.

The creature's momentum carried it forward, but it was already dead. The massive body collapsed, nearly crushing Hayami beneath its weight.

[CRITICAL HIT!]

[BASILISK LORD DEFEATED]

[+9,000 EXP]

[URGENT QUEST COMPLETE!]

[REWARDS: +10,000 EXP, Legendary Reward Box]

[TOTAL: +19,000 EXP]

[LEVEL UP!] x3

[LEVEL 22 → LEVEL 25]

[+15 STAT POINTS AVAILABLE]

Hayami pulled Storm Fang free and stumbled backward, falling to their knees. Every part of their body hurt. But they were alive.

Himiko limped over, transformed back to human form, bleeding from a gash on her forehead. "Did we... did we actually just kill a C-rank boss?"

"Yeah." Hayami's laugh came out slightly hysterical. "We did."

Then the stone door began to grind open.

Nakamura and his team entered the chamber cautiously, weapons drawn, clearly expecting to find corpses and a sleeping boss ready for them to claim an easy kill.

Instead, they found Hayami and Himiko standing over the Basilisk Lord's dissolving body.

The shock on Nakamura's face was almost comical. "What... how..."

"You trapped us." Hayami's voice was flat, cold. "Sealed the door with us inside to die."

Nakamura's expression cycled through surprise, calculation, then settled on something ugly. "So you survived. That's... unfortunate."

His team spread out, forming a semicircle. All five of them, all C-rank, all with weapons drawn.

"The plan was simple," Nakamura continued, his conversational tone chilling. "Trap the rookies with the boss, collect the loot after it kills them, report it as a tragic accident. New Hunters die in Gates all the time. No one questions it."

"You do this regularly?" Himiko's voice shook with anger. "Just... murder people for loot?"

"A-rank or not, you're Level 15 with zero combat experience. And an E-rank..." Nakamura laughed. "Actually, I'm curious how an E-rank managed to help kill a C-rank boss. But it doesn't matter. You're both witnesses now. Can't let you leave."

He turned to Himiko. "Here's the deal. You kill the E-rank, we let you walk. You're A-rank—that makes you valuable. We could use someone like you. Kill Amamiya, and you join our party. Easy choice."

Himiko didn't hesitate. "Go to hell."

Nakamura's expression hardened. "Then you both die. Shame. Would have been useful to have an A-rank." He raised his weapon. "Kill them."

[SYSTEM ALERT]

[URGENT QUEST: ELIMINATE THE BETRAYERS]

[Nakamura's party has attempted to murder you and continues to pose a lethal threat. Eliminate all party members to survive.]

[ENEMIES: 5x C-Rank Hunters (Levels 36-40)]

[COMPLETION REWARD: +15,000 EXP, Title: "Hunter Killer", Legendary Skill Book]

[FAILURE PENALTY: DEATH]

Hayami's mind went cold and clear. Five C-rank Hunters. They were exhausted, low on mana, injured from the boss fight. This should be impossible.

But they'd just killed a Level 45 boss with help from a Level 15 shapeshifter.

And Nakamura had made one critical mistake: he'd given them a quest. The System didn't give quests that were impossible to complete.

Hayami drank their last mana potion. 200 mana. Not much, but enough.

"Himiko, stay behind me. Shift into something small and mobile."

"What are you going to do?"

"Knock them out." Hayami's eyes crackled with lightning. "All of them."

Nakamura's team attacked simultaneously. Coordinated. Professional. Lethal.

Hayami activated Lightning Domain, the hemisphere of electricity springing into existence. The first attacker—the woman with twin daggers—crossed into it and immediately took continuous damage. Not much, but enough to slow her.

Lightning Step carried Hayami past her guard. Stone Fist activated, coating their gauntlets in compressed rock. The punch caught her in the solar plexus, and she went down gasping for air.

[ENEMY DEFEATED: 1/5]

The second attacker came from the side—an archer, launching arrows enhanced with wind magic. Hayami raised Earth Wall, the stone barrier intercepting the projectiles. The wall crumbled, but it bought two seconds.

Two seconds was enough. Advanced Lightning Strike at point-blank range. The archer's armor absorbed most of it, but the electrical current locked his muscles. Hayami followed with a sweep kick enhanced by wind, and he hit the ground hard. A precise strike to the temple with Storm Fang's pommel, and he was unconscious.

[ENEMY DEFEATED: 2/5]

Nakamura realized the situation was wrong. "What the hell? That's not E-rank power!"

"No," Hayami agreed, already moving toward the next target. "It's not."

The third party member was a tank—heavy armor, massive shield, built to absorb damage. Hayami didn't try to go through his defense. Instead: "Stone Prison!"

Earth erupted from below, stone bars cage forming around the tank. He smashed at it with his shield, but the bars held. Trapped, but not defeated. Hayami left him for now—four opponents was more manageable than five.

[ENEMY CONTAINED: 3/5]

The fourth was a mage, launching ice spells from the back line. Dangerous if left unchecked. Hayami channeled wind around themselves, using the element's natural speed enhancement. Lightning Step combined with wind manipulation created a burst of movement faster than they'd managed before.

They crossed the distance in a blur. The mage's eyes widened—she hadn't expected that speed. She started to cast a defensive spell.

Too slow. Hayami's fist, coated in stone and crackling with lightning, caught her in the chest. The Elemental Harmony bonus activated—using three elements in combat for maximum damage. The mage flew backward, hit the wall, and slumped unconscious.

[ENEMY DEFEATED: 4/5]

That left Nakamura.

Level 40. C-rank party leader. Experienced, skilled, and now very aware that he'd underestimated his target.

"You're no E-rank," he said, his weapon—a long sword with fire enchantments—held in a proper guard stance.

"What are you really?"

"Someone who's been training." Hayami's three elements swirled around them—lightning crackling, stone orbiting, wind whistling. "Every. Single. Day."

Nakamura attacked with the skill of hundreds of battles. His technique was flawless, his timing perfect, his power significant. Under normal circumstances, he would have been a serious threat.

But Hayami had just killed a Level 45 boss. A Level 40 Hunter, even an experienced one, was less dangerous.

They fought for thirty seconds—blade against blade, fire against lightning, skill against skill. Nakamura was good. Maybe even great.

But Hayami was better.

Lightning Step to evade a strike. Wind enhancement to counter-attack faster than Nakamura could block. Earth Wall to interrupt his rhythm. Stone Spear to force him into defensive positions.

And when he committed to a powerful overhead strike that would have split Hayami in half—they weren't there. Lightning Step carried them behind him, and Stone Fist struck the back of his head with precisely calculated force.

Enough to knock out. Not enough to kill.

Nakamura collapsed.

[ENEMY DEFEATED: 5/5]

[URGENT QUEST COMPLETE!]

The Stone Prison dissolved, releasing the tank who was still conscious. He looked at his unconscious party members, at Hayami standing over them, and made the smart choice. He dropped his weapon and raised his hands.

"I surrender. Please. I didn't want to do this. Nakamura forced us—"

"Save it." Hayami was too tired for lies. "Himiko, can you tie them up? We need to get out of here and report this to the Association."

Himiko emerged from her hiding spot—she'd been a small lizard on the ceiling, watching everything. She shifted to human form, her expression awed. "You just... you took down five C-rank Hunters. Solo. After fighting a boss. How?"

"Long story." Hayami checked their notifications:

[REWARDS DISTRIBUTED]

[+15,000 EXP]

[LEVEL UP!] x2

[LEVEL 25 → LEVEL 27]

[+10 STAT POINTS AVAILABLE]

[TITLE ACQUIRED: "HUNTER KILLER"] [Effect: +20% damage against other Hunters. +15 to Sense when detecting hostile intent from Hunters.]

[LEGENDARY SKILL BOOK ACQUIRED: "COMBAT ANALYSIS"] [Description: Passively analyze enemy fighting styles, predict attacks, identify weaknesses. Effectiveness scales with Sense and combat experience.]

[LEGENDARY REWARD BOX ACQUIRED] (from boss fight)

Hayami absorbed the Combat Analysis skill immediately. The knowledge flooded in—how to read body language, predict movement patterns, identify gaps in defense. Combined with their Enhanced Perception and the new Hunter Killer title, they would be extraordinarily difficult to ambush or deceive.

They looked at the unconscious Hunters, at Himiko who was processing everything she'd witnessed, at the dissolved Basilisk corpse and the loot it had dropped.

One month and a week since Awakening. Level 27. Two boss kills. Five hostile Hunters defeated. Three elements unlocked. An A-rank ally who'd just witnessed everything.

This was going to be complicated to explain to the Association.

"Come on," Hayami said to Himiko. "Let's get out of here before they wake up."

They left the betrayers tied up in the boss chamber and headed for the exit, carrying evidence and loot. The Association was going to have questions.

But Hayami had survived. Again. And leveled up. Again.

The grind continued.

[END OF CHAPTER 8]